Thereafter, seven more bombs were expected to be available. However, on 10 August 1945 (five days before Emperor Hirohito announced Japan's surrender) Truman ordered the suspension of further atomic attacks on Japan. According to the diary of former Vice President William Wallace (then Commerce Secretary), the President told his cabinet that 'he had given orders to stop the atomic bombing. He said the thought of wiping out another 100,000 people was too horrible. He didn't like the idea of killing, as he said, "all those kids."'[53]

Morality is invariably invisible in the narratives of nuclear history, frequently hidden by assumptions that political leaders are driven solely by 'rational' calculations. Yet, when nuclear weapons were used in 1945, morality was a ghost in the machine. After the war, Truman said he never lost a night's sleep over his decision to use the atomic bomb. The moral defence of the atomic bombing was that it saved the lives of hundreds of thousands of US and allied troops (though such figures are contested), as well as the lives of many thousands of Japanese civilians. Yet, there was a moral element in Truman's mind, both in the decision not to bomb Kyoto and in the decision not to drop the third bomb (at least not yet).

The aurora borealis

'Historians don't really like to deal with counterfactuals,' Robert McNamara once complained.[54] In fact, counterfactuals in one form or another are essential to exploring alternative outcomes, including the risk of nuclear war. How might nuclear war have started? How might it have escalated to Armageddon (and beyond)? Several scenarios are explored in chapter seven. One is discussed here, which illuminates various aspects of the crisis.

For many years, 27 October 1962 has been referred to as Black Saturday. According to Michael Dobbs, 'If the Cuban missile crisis was the defining moment of the Cold War, Black Saturday was the defining moment of the missile crisis. It was then that the hands of the metaphorical doomsday clock reached one minute to midnight.'[55] There is one particular moment when the clock ticked very loudly, when midnight might have been very